FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

FINISHING WHAT THEY START

Keeping a promise to the team, without the resentment

THE QUICK VERSION

> When your child wants to stop halfway through a season, it's one of the toughest spots for a parent. Their happiness matters. So does learning to honour a promise. The good news is you don't have to choose one over the other. How you talk about it makes all the difference.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Signing up for a team isn't just a personal choice. It's a promise to a group of teammates and coaches who are now counting on them. Finishing the season, even when it gets hard, boring or frustrating, can teach lessons that last well beyond football. The key is helping your child feel heard, not forced.

WHAT FINISHING THE SEASON TEACHES

KEEPING A PROMISE

- Signing up is a commitment to a group
- Teammates and coaches are counting on them
- Their word means something

RESILIENCE

- Hard, boring or frustrating isn't a reason to walk away straight away
- Getting through discomfort builds confidence

TEAM FIRST

- Missing games affects game time and positions for the whole team
- It builds empathy and loyalty

Commitment, not punishment

Finishing the season should never feel like a punishment for wanting to stop. Agree on the finish line, then make it clear the choice about next season is theirs. Important: if your child is unsafe, being bullied or treated badly, their wellbeing always comes first. Speak to the club straight away.

TRY THIS

1 Validate the exit strategy
"It's 100% okay if you don't want to play next season. But you made a promise to this team for this season, and we honour our promises."

2 Shift the goalposts
If winning no longer motivates them, set a new goal: be the best teammate, master one skill, or simply enjoy the exercise.

3 Avoid guilt-tripping
Frame it around pride and reliability, not shame. "They're counting on you," never "You're letting everyone down."

4 Listen before you decide
Bored, lonely, nervous or overloaded? Each needs a different answer, and some can be fixed.

5 Set a clear finish line
Name the date: the last game, the end of term. A visible end point makes it manageable.

6 Celebrate finishing
When the season ends, tell them you're proud they saw it through. Then keep your promise about next season.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"I hear you. Let's finish strong, then you choose."	~~"You're not quitting, end of discussion."~~
"Your teammates are counting on you."	~~"You're letting everyone down."~~
"I'm proud of you for sticking with it."	~~"See, I told you it wasn't that bad."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] I found out the real reason before deciding
- [ ] My child knows exactly when the season ends
- [ ] They know next season is their choice
- [ ] I've ruled out any safety or wellbeing concerns

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

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Seeing a season through when it's hard is one of the first big promises a young player keeps. That lesson stays with them long after the final whistle.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM